World War II Cheema had been a POW of the Italians and was known to be terrified of falling into the hands of the Chinese. The two battalions under his command—4 Rajput and 19 MLI—were strung out defending the various tracks and approaches but the brigade commander rarely, if ever, visited any of the men under his own command, preferring to stick close to Pathania and literally became his shadow. Cheema's professional competence was suspect, yet he was hand-picked by Thapar to command 65 Brigade at this critical time.

Cheema had arrived at the Division HQ for the conference all packed and ready to go. Shortly after Pathania's departure, along with Brigadier Gurbax Singh Gill, commander 4 Artillery Brigade and Brigadier Michael Chatterjee, commander 67 Infantry Brigade (on a reconnaissance trip to Dirang before the induction of his brigade into Bomdila), the convoy of fleeing brigadiers took off after Pathania without so much as a by your leave to any of the troops who were still left in Dirang, to say nothing of 4 Rajput and 19 MLI. As the convoy took off, Cheema was shouting 'Manda-la track, Manda-la track' presumably for the benefit of the vehicles behind him.

THE BIG THREE AT TEZPUR (18 NOVEMBER)

In the morning, Bogey Sen and his BGS, Brigadier Sibal, had dropped in at the Circuit House where the chief had spent the night. All three officers were blissfully unaware of developments either in Se-la or Dirang Dzong. Sen, in fact, was still trying to convince Thapar on the merits of withdrawing from Se-la, when Monty Palit returned from his early morning visit to Kaul and IV Corps HQ.

'4 Infantry Division has pulled out without orders and without offering battle. Sometime between midnight and this morning our forces ran away from Se-la, Senge and Dirang. They seemed to have abandoned all their wireless sets because there has been no further contact with any formation or unit thereafter.'

Both the COAS and the Eastern Army Commander had commanded the Red Eagles during their careers and the stunning news of its disintegration in a matter of hours was a blow. The party made its way to the Ops Room at IV Corps HQ where Kaul was waiting for them. The corps commander brought Thapar and Sen up to date on the developments of the previous night; of Se-la the Corps HQ knew next to nothing other than the fact that